PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Week 2: Social Movement Theory

1. Course Framing: Core Questions

Keywords: participation, grievances, mass mobilisation, success, globalisation, contested answers

- What does it take for people to rebel against, or join movements pressing demands on, authority?
- What drives involvement? Under what conditions? How do people become willing to die for others?
- How does mass participation translate into social (sometimes revolutionary) change? What makes a movement succeed or fail?
- How does globalisation affect domestic contentious politics?

Warning: answers in social science are contested. Treat each theory as a competing answer — know what problem it solves and what problem it leaves behind.

2. Definitions: What Counts as a Social Movement

Keywords: collective behaviour, continuity, noninstitutional politics, SMO, dimensions of variation

Three classic definitions (slide 2), a progression from broad/expressive → precise/institutional. All three contested.

2.1 Blumer 1939 — Broadest

Keywords: emergent behaviour, unrest, new order of life, no organisation required

- Social movements can be viewed as collective enterprises to establish a new order of life. They have their inception in the condition of unrest, and derive their motive power on one hand from dissatisfaction with the current form of life, and on the other hand, from wishes and hopes for a new scheme or system of living (Blumer 1939).
- Requires **no** organisation, formal membership, or explicit political demand — only a shared orientation toward a new order of life.

2.2 Turner & Killian 1972 — Adds Continuity

Keywords: continuity, promote OR resist change, informal leadership, shifting membership

- A social movement is a collectivity acting with some continuity to promote or resist a change in the society or organization of which it is a part... (Turner & Killian 1972).
- Adds two elements absent in Blumer: **continuity over time**, and movements can promote **or resist** change — reactionary movements count too.

2.3 McAdam 1982 — Most Political

Keywords: excluded groups, noninstitutional participation, organised effort, protest vs party politics

- Social movements are those organized efforts, on the part of excluded groups, to promote or resist changes in the structure of society that involve recourse to noninstitutional forms of political participation (McAdam 1982).
- Adds: organisation, exclusion from normal channels, noninstitutional tactics.

2.4 Movement vs SMO

Keywords: social movement, social movement organisation, conflation

- Broad movement (the women's movement) ≠ specific organisation (one advocacy group). Often conflated; different theories explain one better than the other.

2.5 Dimensions of Variation (slide 3)

Keywords: goals, spatial scope, targets, tactics — case-study checklist

- Causes/goals: from radical re-organisation of society to narrowly defined issues.
- Spatial/political organisation: local, national, transnational.
- Targets of demands: inter-governmental orgs, non-governmental orgs, national governments, corporations.
- Methods/tactics.

→ Use as checklist for any case study; explains why no single theory fits all movements.

3. Relative Deprivation (Gurr 1970)

Keywords: frustration-aggression, relative vs absolute deprivation, grievance, entitlement gap

First theory of protest; almost every later approach is defined by its rejection of it.

3.1 Core Mechanism (slides 5–6)

Keywords: frustration → anger → violence, felt entitlement, hypothesis

- Ted Robert Gurr (1970), *Why Men Rebel*. Assumption: the most dangerous source of political violence is the frustration-aggression mechanism; a prolonged feeling of frustration will lead to anger/violence (Frustration-Aggression).
- Mechanism: **frustration → anger → violence**.
- Key move: frustration is **not** about absolute misery — people get used to terrible circumstances.
- Relative deprivation is the difference between what a person has and what the person in question believes he/she deserves.
- Hypothesis: "The potential for collective violence varies strongly with the intensity and scope of relative deprivation among members of a collectivity."
- **Relative deprivation → frustration (→ aggression); absolute deprivation → only desperation.**

- Prediction: protesters are **not the poorest** — they are those with the largest gap between what they have and what they feel entitled to. *Example: two equally poor villages — one isolated, one next to a visibly wealthy elite — theory predicts revolt in the second.*

3.2 Three Problems (slides 7–9)

Keywords: causal status, reversed causation, inaction, free riding

- **P1 — Causal status unclear (slide 7):** not a *sufficient* cause (many deprived people never protest). As *necessary/contributing* cause it is trivial: "protesters have grievances" is obvious, explains little.
- **P2 — Causation runs backwards (slide 8):** shared feelings of deprivation rarely arise spontaneously from material conditions. Deeply felt, shared grievances are usually the **result of mobilisation, not its cause**.
- **P3 — Deprivation produces inaction (slide 9):** even aggrieved people rationally sit back and **free ride** — let others do the work. → Collective Action Problem. Hinge of the whole lecture.

4. The Collective Action Problem (Olson 1965)

Keywords: public goods, non-excludability, free riding, individually rational → collectively irrational

4.1 The Logic (slides 10–11)

Keywords: private costs, group size, dominant free-riding

- Mancur Olson (1965), *The Logic of Collective Action*: rational individuals with common grievances/interests have **no incentive** to join organisations furthering those interests.
- Collective action provides "public goods" (PGs), which are "non-excludable" in the sense that one cannot discriminate between "participant" and "free-rider" when such goods are distributed — either everyone enjoys them, or no one does. *Examples: clean air, national security, democracy.*
- Two steps:
- Participation has **private costs** (time, energy, money), while the good is shared by all.
- In a large group, one person's contribution makes **no difference** to success or failure.
- Logic of free riding — because the public good arrives whether or not one participates, the rationally calculating individual waits for others to act; if everyone reasons this way, the good is never provided, so individually rational behaviour produces a collectively irrational outcome.

4.2 Worked Example: Jane (slide 12)

Keywords: 2x2 game, dominant strategy, instrumental rationality

Jane in an autocracy, deciding whether to join a pro-democracy demonstration. Assume: if all supporters attend, democracy is established.

Jane's choice	**Everyone else protests**	**Everyone else stays home**
Protest	Democracy − time lost	Nothing − time lost

Jane's choice	Everyone else protests	Everyone else stays home
Stay home	Democracy − nothing	Nothing

- "Instrumentally rational" — meaning, if she takes the course of action that guarantees the highest payoff (calculated as benefits minus costs) → Jane **always stays home**.
- Staying home is **dominant**: never worse than protesting. If everyone reasons so, the demonstration fails. Collective action problem in pure form.

5. Rational Choice Fixes & Their Limits

Keywords: selective incentives, selective disincentives, excludable benefits, coercion, explains inaction > action

5.1 Two Devices (slide 13)

Keywords: private payoff, sanctions, cost of staying home

- Selective incentives: unlike public goods, these are "excludable" benefits — that is, benefits that are only given to those who actively participate — money, or "social benefits". *Example: union members-only insurance or legal aid.* Restores a private payoff to participation.
- Selective disincentives: sanctions/penalties assessed on those who do not participate (thereby making it "costly" to stay home) — physical coercion/violence, "social sanctions". *Example: closed-shop rules, social ostracism of non-joiners.*

Both devices convert the public-goods problem back into an ordinary cost-benefit calculation.

5.2 Why Insufficient (slides 14–15)

Keywords: inaction vs action, balance sheet, movements produce grievances

- Rational choice explains why people **do NOT** act — weak at explaining why some **do**.
- Balance sheet (memorise):
- Deprivation is **not enough** to make most people participate (else protest everywhere, always).
- Self-interest is **not powerful enough** to stop people from participating (else almost nobody would protest).
- Conclusion: the interesting questions are how movements **actively foster shared grievances** and **translate them into action**, often by inducing followers to overlook self-interest. Grievance and rationality are **produced by movements**, not fixed inputs.

6. Skocpol's Non-Voluntarism (Structuralism, 1979)

Keywords: structural causes, purposive explanations rejected, necessary-and-sufficient conditions, no micro-mechanism

6.1 Core Claim (slides 16–19)

Keywords: "revolutions are not made", crisis exploitation, international context

- Theda Skocpol (1979), *States and Social Revolutions* (cases: France 1789, Russia 1917, China 1949).
- No revolution has ever been "made" by revolutionaries. Good explanation must rise above participants' viewpoints, grievances, interests.
- Revolutions have "structural" causes, to be found especially in the international and socio-economic context in which a particular society finds itself at a particular time.
- Historical claim: no successful social revolution has ever been "made" by a mass-mobilising, avowedly revolutionary movement. Vanguards cement solidarity and consolidate new regimes — but never create the crises they exploit.
- Jeremy Brecher: "revolutionary movements rarely begin with a revolutionary intention; this only develops in the course of the struggle itself."
- Wendell Phillips: "Revolutions are not made; they come."

6.2 Three Necessary-and-Sufficient Conditions (slide 20)

Keywords: international pressure, elite resistance, mobilising organisations, class realignment

Structuralism defines social revolutions as a radical realignment in class relations. Conditions:

- International pressure from more advanced states (intense after war defeats or threats of invasion).
- Economic/political elites with enough autonomy and power to **resist state reforms** (reforms launched to extract resources for confronting the international threat) → precipitate crisis.
- Organisations exist to mobilise lower classes and **exploit elite conflict** to radically transform state and society.

6.3 Critique (slide 21)

Keywords: other destabilisers, agency and ideas, collective action problem unsolved

- Revolutions can happen without a threatening international context (e.g., population growth). Outcomes also shaped by revolutionaries' ideas and choices — same structures, different movements → different outcomes.
- **Fatal for this course:** no mechanism linking structure to mass mobilisation. How do elite divisions make someone willing to die in the street? Structure explains the crisis, **not the bodies in the street**.

7. Political Opportunity Structures (McTT) — Origin & Fusion

Keywords: structuralist + voluntarist, Tilly's critique, resource mobilisation, political process

- D. McAdam, S. Tarrow, C. Tilly (McTT) → Political Opportunity Structures (P.O.S.). Dominant approach in social movement theory.
- Character: still largely structuralist, but more "voluntaristic" — integrates culture and rationality; agency gets more room than in Skocpol.
- **Origin:** Tilly's critique of relative deprivation — protest comes not from grievances but from **organised contenders mobilising resources and popular support effectively**. Decisive break from Section 3.

7.1 Resource Mobilisation (slide 23)

Keywords: inside the movement, resources over grievances, professional protester

- The resource mobilisation approach examines the variety of resources that must be mobilised, the linkages of social movements to other groups, the dependence of movements upon external support for success, and the tactics used by authorities to control or incorporate movements (McCarthy and Zald 1977).
- Success aided by the target group's **pre-existing organisation** and integration/cohesiveness.
- Protester pictured: rational, well-organised, professional, resourceful — undertakes well-planned collective action. (Contrast: angry, frustrated individual of relative deprivation.)

7.2 Political Process (slide 24)

Keywords: outside the movement, political-institutional environment, cross-national variation

- While resource mobilisation theorists explain the rise and fall of social movements by features internal to the movements themselves, such as the availability of resources and organisational aspects, political process theorists focus on external features, like changes or differences in the political and institutional environment of social movements.
- Paradigm statement: changes in or differences between **political structures** are the main explanation for movements' rise and fall; country/era differences stem from how a national political system shapes, checks, absorbs challenges.
- *Example: McAdam's own study — the US civil rights movement (Political Process and the Development of Black Insurgency, 1982).*
- **One-liner: RM looks inside the movement; PP looks outside it. P.O.S. fuses both.**

7.3 The Tripartite Scheme (slide 25)

Keywords: three components, taken together

- Political opportunities/constraints
- Mobilisation structures
- Cognitive frames

→ Structural opening + organisational capacity + meaning-making. Core of the week's theory content.

8. Component 1: Political Opportunities & Constraints (slides 25–26)

Keywords: structural conditions, costs of participation, expectations of success, comparative method

- Defined as structural conditions whose change over time makes dissidents more/less likely to act, or creates more or less favourable circumstances for the success of the mobilisation process.
- Resembles Skocpol (revolutionaries don't "make" the crises they exploit) but covers a **broader range** of structural factors. Examples listed: international pressures, political reforms, elite divisions, socio-economic/demographic/technological change, economic crisis/depression.

- **Answer to Olson:** opportunities link structure to individual behaviour by changing the **costs of participation**.
- Formal definition: "Political opportunities" are consistent — not necessarily formal or permanent — dimensions of a political environment that provide incentives for collective actions by affecting people's expectation for success or failure. "Political constraints" do the opposite.
- Used comparatively to explain cross-national variation in protest.

9. Component 2: Mobilisation Structures (slides 27–29)

Keywords: hierarchical organisation, trust, coordination, resource types, pre-existing networks

- Definition: the capacity to put together hierarchical organisations that link leaders/followers, centre/periphery, and different wings of the movement together — key in order to establish trust, mobilise resources, and coordinate action.
- Often crucial: reliance on resources mobilised through **pre-existing social relations, institutions, organisations**.

Resource Types (exam-friendly)

- **Organisational:** money, training, weapons, safe houses, bases. Sources: contributors/patrons (domestic or foreign), or illicit profits (kidnapping, bank robbery, drug trafficking).
- **Pre-existing organisations:** black churches (US civil rights), mosques (1979 Iranian revolution), labour unions (socialist movements), professional associations (middle classes).
- **Leadership:** experienced leaders with vision, know-how, strategic acumen, oratory/organisational skills.
- **Cultural/symbolic/intellectual:** endorsement by communal elites (religious/ethnic leaders), intellectuals, widely respected celebrities/organisations → visibility and credibility. Plus appropriation of established, meaningful **symbols** → movement looks worth joining, gains cultural/historical legitimacy.

10. Component 3: Cognitive Frames (slide 30)

Keywords: cognitive framework, narrative, ideology, leader agency, voluntarism

- Cognitive frames refer to the capacity of leaders to provide a cognitive framework that convinces supporters of the need to protest and of the likely effectiveness of doing so.
- Key: ideology and/or narrative of historical purpose/mission; the words chosen to inspire.
- *Examples: "I Have a Dream" (civil rights), "We are the 99%" (Occupy), "Black Lives Matter" (framing police violence as systemic injustice).*
- Theoretical consequence: outcomes become sensitive to **choice** and to leaders' capacity to shape followers' cognitive and decision-making processes → this is what makes P.O.S. more **voluntaristic** than Skocpol.

11. Critiques of P.O.S. (slides 31–35)

Keywords: retrospective fallacy, negative cases, perception fix, structure sets odds not results

- **[i] Retrospective fallacy (slide 31):** start from a successful movement and look back for the "opportunity" that caused it — assumes the answer. No criteria to identify opportunities **independently of outcomes** ("to know one when one sees one").
- **[ii] Negative cases (slide 32):** objective opportunities often don't correspond to action (elite divisions don't always cause mobilisation). Theorists then explain non-mobilisation ad hoc via weak resources/framing. Again assumes the answer; still **no mechanism** for individual mobilisation — "opportunities lower costs" barely addresses the collective action problem.
- **[iii] Perception fix fails to settle it (slide 33):** opportunities matter only when **perceived** — which is what P.O.S. scholars say. But followers can be made to feel opportunities (like grievances) exist regardless of objective conditions. Question shifts from "which opportunities cause action" to "how do participants come to **perceive** them through mobilisation" — back to perception, framing, motivation. Lands exactly where Section 3 left off.
- **Balanced conclusion (slide 34):** structure still matters — class relations, international context, elite divisions, state formation, nation building set the **obstacles and options** leaders face (e.g., no peasant revolution in advanced industrial societies). But structure does **not** determine outcomes; choice and chance matter; specific outbreaks unpredictable. **Memorise: structure sets the odds, it does not fix the result.**
- **Slide 35:** outcomes determined by leaders' responses to structural challenges/incentives/constraints, success in motivating followers, and strategic interaction with the state and other actors. → Tactics/strategy = Week 4. Collective action problem = Week 3.

12. Preview: Beyond Self-Interest (slides 36–37)

Keywords: emotions, self-categorisation, parochial altruism, moral agents, social embeddedness

Slide 36 — return to the individual, but beyond self-interest: - Add the instinctive, emotional, moral bases of action; mobilisation + framing activate psychological mechanisms/processes. - See individuals as **embedded in webs of social relations** (family, friends, school, work, political/social/communal organisations, class, ethnicity, region) → preferences, values, worldviews, identities. - Communities shape action via social/psychological **rewards and costs**.

Slide 37 — what else motivates behaviour? - **[i] Passions/emotions:** anger, resentment, fear, urge to fit in (or stand out). People care about **self-image and public image** → often think not very rationally, act against self-interest. - **[ii]** "Self-categorization" (i.e., defining their identity in terms of group membership) and "parochial altruism" (i.e., favouring people, even unknown people, seen as members of the same group, while discriminating against others). - **[iii]** Humans are, in Jeremy Beetham's words, "moral agents" who have "some notion of the common interest, and acknowledge the binding force of promises they have made" — do what they think is right even against self-interest. (Caveat: not always a good thing.)

→ Bridge to Week 3: collective action revisited with identity, emotion, morality in the model.

13. One-Page Revision Spine

1. **Definitions:** Blumer 1939 → Turner & Killian 1972 → McAdam 1982; movement vs SMO; dimensions of variation.
2. **Relative Deprivation (Gurr 1970):** frustration-aggression; relative vs absolute deprivation; three failures (unclear causal status, reversed causation, inaction/free riding).

3. **Collective Action Problem (Olson 1965):** non-excludable public goods; free riding dominant; Jane 2x2 example.
4. **Rational Choice fixes:** selective incentives/disincentives; explains inaction better than action.
5. **Non-Voluntarism (Skocpol 1979):** structural causes; three necessary-and-sufficient conditions; no mechanism for mass mobilisation.
6. **Resource Mobilization (McCarthy & Zald 1977) + Political Process → P.O.S. (McAdam, Tarrow, Tilly);** born from Tilly's critique of relative deprivation.
7. **McTT components:** opportunities/constraints; mobilisation structures (resource types); cognitive frames.
8. **Critiques of P.O.S.:** retrospective fallacy; negative cases explained away; perception fix still leaves no mechanism.
9. **Resolution:** structure sets odds, not results; leaders' responses + motivation + strategic interaction → Weeks 3 & 4.
10. **Preview:** emotion, self-categorisation, parochial altruism, moral agency.